

A SELF-DIAGNOSTIC FOR FOUNDERS

The 7 Signs

Your Business Is Disconnected

Where you score, where you drag, and what to do about it.

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BEFORE YOU START

Companies don't break down suddenly.

They calcify into who they used to be.

You built something that worked. You hired. You added tools. You added offers. You added team. Each decision was right at the time.

But over years, a layer forms. Systems duct-taped together. Roles fuzzy. Meetings stacked on meetings. Marketing promising what operations can't deliver. The founder doing five jobs.

Nothing is broken. Everything drags.

This booklet is a diagnostic. Not a sales pitch. By the time you finish it, you'll know exactly where your business is leaking time, money, and energy — and which area to fix first.

It's based on what I've seen across 35+ years inside businesses in 14 countries — from 3-person shops in Margarita Island to 50-person sales teams in Santiago to nonprofits in Philadelphia handling federal funding during a pandemic. The patterns repeat. They're in this booklet.

HOW TO USE THIS

Twenty-one questions across seven areas. Three questions per area. Rate yourself honestly — 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

Add your three scores to get a total per area. Then add all seven area scores at the end.

It takes 10 minutes. Be honest. The booklet only works if you are.

If you've already taken the online quiz, the same questions are inside — this booklet is your reference and your action plan. Keep it. Mark it up. Come back to it next quarter.

Strategic & Leadership Alignment

Picture the founder of a 30-person services firm in Santiago. She's brilliant. She has a clear three-year vision. She's communicated it in three all-hands meetings, two emails, and a one-page strategy doc.

I sat down with seven of her direct reports over two days. I asked each one the same question: "What are the top three priorities for this year?"

I got seven different answers. Three of them contradicted each other.

She didn't have a strategy problem. She had a translation problem. Her vision lived in her head and in her one-pager — but it never made the jump to the daily decisions her team was making at 11am on a Tuesday.

THE PATTERN

The business has direction. But that direction is not always translating into consistent decisions across the team. Priorities get interpreted differently depending on who's in the room. Decisions get revisited because no one is sure they were really decided. The founder ends up carrying the operational weight because she's the only one holding the full picture.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

1. If I asked three different people on my team what our top priority is this quarter, would I get the same answer?
2. Decisions made in leadership meetings are still being revisited or re-debated weeks later.
3. I am the bottleneck for too many decisions that my team should be able to make without me.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / 15

3–6 running clean · 7–10 drag forming · 11–15 calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Decisions that should take a day take a week. Opportunities expire while you're still aligning. You're exhausted not from working — from re-explaining. The team isn't disengaged; they're just guessing.



When the strategy lives only in the founder's head, the team can't execute it — they can only orbit it.

Operational Structure & Systems

A nonprofit in Philadelphia, March 2020. The pandemic just hit. Federal PPP funding had been announced — billions of dollars sitting in the system, waiting to be claimed by small businesses that desperately needed it.

But the org's intake process was a 12-year-old maze of paper forms, spreadsheets that nobody owned, and a phone tree that routed everything to one overworked staffer. Three weeks in, they'd processed nine applications.

I came in. We mapped the whole flow on a wall in 90 minutes. Eighty percent of it was duplicated work, manual handoffs, or steps no one could explain the purpose of.

We rebuilt the intake from scratch in five days. Ninety days later we'd routed \$1.3M to over 300 businesses. Same staff. Same office. Different structure.

THE PATTERN

The business is running. But it's running on duct tape and willpower. Processes are unclear, duplicated, or done manually when they should be automated. Tools exist but nobody uses them, or three tools do the same thing badly. Workflows create friction instead of flow. Everything works — but it costs three times as much energy as it should.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

- 1.** I can describe, in writing, how at least three of our core processes are supposed to run — and I'd find them being done that way if I checked tomorrow.
- 2.** The tools we pay for (CRM, project management, email, automation) are actually being used the way they were designed to be used.
- 3.** When something goes wrong, we can trace it back to a clear breakdown in a process — not just a person who dropped a ball.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / **15**

3–6 running clean · **7–10** drag forming · **11–15** calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Time loss across every team, every week. Higher operational cost than your competitors. Things slip through the cracks not because anyone is lazy, but because the system has cracks. You hire to solve problems that better systems would have prevented.

Most businesses don't need new tools. They need to actually use the ones they have.

Team Clarity, Training & Autonomy

Liquimoly Chile. A 50-person sales team. Revenue had been declining for two years. Everyone blamed the market. The market wasn't great, but it wasn't the problem.

I spent a week sitting with sales reps. They were capable. They were trying. But nobody had been formally trained in over three years. New hires were learning by watching the person next to them — who had also learned by watching the person next to them. Each generation a little fuzzier.

Expectations weren't documented. Targets shifted quarterly without explanation. Decisions that should have taken five minutes took a week because every rep needed manager approval to do anything outside the script — except the script was eight years out of date.

We rebuilt training, defined roles, gave reps the authority to make calls in their own accounts. Twelve months later: revenue up 36%. Costs down 10%. Same team. Different operating model.

THE PATTERN

Your people are good. They want to perform. But they're not fully equipped or aligned to do their best work. Training is informal — “shadow Maria for a week.” Expectations live in someone's head, not on paper. The team escalates everything to leadership because no one is sure what they're authorized to decide. So you become the bottleneck for problems your team should be solving.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

- 1.** A new hire on my team can become productive within their first 30 days using documented training — not by shadowing someone.
- 2.** Every person on my team can tell me, without hesitation, what success looks like in their role this quarter.
- 3.** My team makes decisions in their domains without escalating to me — and I trust those decisions.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / **15**

3–6 running clean · **7–10** drag forming · **11–15** calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Slower execution. Inconsistent performance. Founder dependency. You can't take a vacation without things slipping. Your best people leave because they want to grow into authority you haven't structured yet. Your weaker people stay because no one's defined what they should be doing.

An untrained, unauthorized team isn't lazy. It's waiting.

SIGN 04

Product, Offer & Company Clarity

I was hired by a wellness brand in Miami — beautiful product, devoted customers, three years old. Revenue was plateauing and they couldn't figure out why.

I asked the founder to describe what the company sold. She gave me a beautiful answer.

Then I asked her head of sales the same question. Different answer.

Marketing lead: third answer.

Customer service: “Honestly I tell people whatever they ask about, and they figure out if it's right for them.”

Four employees. Four different versions of what the company actually does. Customers were getting four different stories — and converting at the rate you'd expect.

THE PATTERN

Your business is strong. But internal understanding of what makes it strong is not aligned. Different people on your team describe the company and the offers differently. The value is real — but no one articulates it the same way twice. Differentiation lives in your head; everyone else is approximating.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

1. If I asked three different people in my company to describe what we do and why we're different, I'd get the same answer in substance.
2. We have a clear, written articulation of our offers — what they include, who they're for, and what outcome they produce.
3. Our team can explain in one sentence why a customer should choose us over a direct competitor.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / 15

3–6 running clean · 7–10 drag forming · 11–15 calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Weaker positioning in every conversation. Sales reps who pitch differently every time. Marketing that sounds generic because it has to cover all the possible interpretations. Customers who can't quite explain why they hired you when their friends ask. Referrals that don't happen because no one knows what to refer.



If your team can't explain your business in one sentence, your customers can't either.

Marketing & Sales Alignment

A bilingual services business in Texas — owners are Mexican-American, customer base is half English, half Spanish. They were spending \$8,000 a month on marketing and getting plenty of leads.

But conversion was awful. Sales calls felt like first dates with someone who'd read a different profile.

The marketing was running campaigns based on what the marketing agency thought would convert. The sales team was selling something subtly different — based on what they'd learned actually closed deals on calls. The website said one thing. The sales scripts said another. The Spanish-language ads were direct translations of the English ones, missing the cultural nuance entirely.

Every part was working. None of them were working together. We rebuilt the messaging from scratch — once, with sales and marketing in the same room — and rewrote the Spanish materials from the ground up, not from translation. Conversion doubled in six weeks.

THE PATTERN

The business knows what it does. But that clarity isn't fully translating into the market. Marketing generates activity but not consistently qualified demand. Sales conversations vary in quality depending on who's on the call. Messaging is inconsistent across touchpoints — your website says one thing, your ads say another, your reps say a third. If you serve a bilingual or Hispanic market, your Spanish messaging is probably translated, not built.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

- 1.** The message a prospect sees in our marketing matches what they hear when they get on a sales call with us.
- 2.** Every salesperson on my team closes at roughly the same rate — meaning the process works, not just the rockstar.
- 3.** If we serve a bilingual or Hispanic market, our messaging in that language was built for that audience — not translated from English.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / **15**

3–6 running clean · **7–10** drag forming · **11–15** calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Lower conversion. Longer sales cycles. Marketing budget feeding leads that sales can't close. Sales blaming marketing. Marketing blaming sales. Both blaming the market. Revenue that should be there is leaking out at the seam between the two functions.

Marketing brings them to the door. Sales decides what they walk into. If those are different rooms, you lose them.

Customer Experience & Delivery Consistency

A boutique consulting firm I worked with had a stellar founder and a great reputation. New clients came in glowing. Six months later, half had quietly stopped engaging.

I dug in. The founder personally onboarded every new client — that part was magic. But after week three, the work transitioned to junior consultants. The drop was vertical. Not because the juniors were bad. Because there was no playbook. Each junior delivered a slightly different version of the firm's work. Some clients got white-glove. Some got the rushed version. None of them knew what to expect, so disappointment was inevitable.

We built one playbook. Every client now got the same experience regardless of who delivered it. Retention went from 50% to 87% in nine months.

THE PATTERN

The client experience is not as seamless as the business intends. Different customers have different experiences depending on which day they came in or which person handled them. There are gaps between what was promised in the sale and what gets delivered. Standardization exists in your head but not in your operating reality.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

1. A customer who interacts with us through three different channels (sales, support, delivery) gets a consistent experience and consistent quality.
2. What we promise during the sales process is reliably what gets delivered after the contract is signed.
3. Our customers refer us to others without us asking — because they know exactly what they got and can describe it.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / 15

3–6 running clean · 7–10 drag forming · 11–15 calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Reduced trust. Lower retention. Clients who don't churn loudly — they just don't renew, don't refer, don't come back. You spend three times more acquiring new customers than you would

keeping existing ones. Word of mouth slows because no one is sure which version of you to recommend.

Customers don't leave because of one bad experience. They leave because the experience was inconsistent enough that they stopped trusting you.

Revenue Optimization (The Outcome Layer)

This is the area founders point to first. “My revenue isn't where it should be.”

It's almost never the actual problem. It's the symptom of all six signs above it.

The Liquimoly turnaround, the Philadelphia PPP rescue, the Miami wellness brand, the bilingual Texas firm — every one of them came to me describing a revenue problem. None of them had a revenue problem in isolation. They had alignment problems, structure problems, clarity problems, delivery problems. Revenue was just where the bleeding showed up.

Fix the bleeding by patching revenue and it comes back next quarter. Fix the upstream signs and revenue rises on its own — and stays risen.

THE PATTERN

The business is working. Money is coming in. But revenue is not fully reflecting the business's true capacity. Opportunities are missed because no one was watching for them. Conversion is leaving money on the table at every stage. Efficiency improvements that would drop straight to the bottom line are sitting unaddressed because everyone is too busy to see them.

ASK YOURSELF

Rate each from 1 (never true) to 5 (always true).

1. I know, with confidence, what our revenue could be if every other area in this booklet was running clean.
2. We measure conversion at every stage of our pipeline — and we know which stage is leaking the most.
3. If I had to grow revenue 30% in the next year, I have a clear plan for where it would come from — not just a hope.

YOUR SCORE FOR THIS AREA

Add your three answers above: _____ / **15**

3–6 running clean · **7–10** drag forming · **11–15** calcified

WHAT THIS IS COSTING YOU

Revenue below true capacity. The gap between what your business is and what it could be — and that gap is what you feel at 2am when you can't sleep. It's not that the business isn't working. It's that you can sense it isn't working at the level it should be.

Revenue is the last sign because it's the last symptom. Fix the first six and the seventh fixes itself.

NOW ADD IT UP

Your total score.

Add your seven area scores together for a total out of 105.

TOTAL SCORE	WHERE YOU ARE	WHAT IT MEANS
21–42	Running clean	Your business is in the top tier of operational coherence. Some refinement opportunities exist, but the foundation is healthy. Focus on your one weakest area.
43–73	Drag forming	The business is functioning, but you're paying a tax in time, energy, and revenue every week. Multiple areas need work. The highest-leverage move is a Diagnostic to map exactly where the drag is concentrated.
74–105	Calcified	The business is working — but it's working against itself across multiple systems. You feel this every day. The good news: businesses at this score have the most upside when they get aligned. Don't keep patching. Get help.

NOW FIND YOUR WEAKEST SINGLE AREA

Look at your seven area scores. Which one is the highest?

That area is your highest-leverage starting point. It's where the most pain lives — and therefore where fixing first will free up the most energy across everything else.

Most founders try to fix everything at once, get overwhelmed, and end up fixing nothing. The discipline is to fix one area at a time — the right one — and let the others get easier as a result.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Three paths.

One starts a 30-minute conversation.

01 IF YOU SCORED 21–42 (Running Clean)

You have a strong foundation. You don't need to overhaul anything. Pick your single weakest area and address it specifically — through your team, through better documentation, or through a focused engagement on that one area.

Recommended next step: Self-directed work, or a single-area Diagnostic if you want a second pair of eyes.

02 IF YOU SCORED 43–73 (Drag Forming)

You're in the most common range. The business works, but you can feel the friction. Multiple areas need attention, and trying to fix them in your spare time will take years.

Recommended next step: Start with a Diagnostic (\$2,500–\$5,000, 2–3 weeks). I look at all seven areas, identify exactly where the drag is concentrated, and give you a written plan you can either execute yourself or hand to me to execute as The Fix.

03 IF YOU SCORED 74–105 (Calcified)

The business is working against itself across multiple systems. You don't need more analysis — you've been analyzing it in your head for months. You need execution.

Recommended next step: Skip the Diagnostic and book a Strategy Call directly. We'll talk about The Fix (60–120 days, \$7,500–\$20,000) or The Operating Partnership (\$5,000–\$10,000/mo) depending on what you need.

THE STRATEGY CALL

30 minutes. No pitch.

I tell you exactly what I see.

Bring your scores from this booklet. We'll talk through where you landed and what it means for your specific business. If I can help, I'll tell you how. If I can't, I'll tell you that too — and where to go instead.

You leave with clarity either way.

Book at: gillianparkinsonf.com

WHO WROTE THIS

Gillian Parkinson Farfán

Growth & Execution Operator. Fractional COO.

35+ years inside businesses across 14 countries. Two languages. One obsession: making businesses actually work — not on paper, in practice.

I've spent decades fixing, organizing, and rebuilding companies that have strong ideas but broken execution. From Margarita Island to Caracas to Santiago to Philadelphia, I've walked into companies where nothing was connecting and left them running.

I am obsessive about order. Dyslexic, which means I see problems from angles most people miss. I dropped out of school at fifteen. I've outperformed expectations in every room I've walked into. Make of that what you will.

I work in English and Spanish. I understand the US Hispanic market from the inside — not from a report. The fastest growing segment of US small business is Hispanic-owned, and almost nobody is serving them at this level.

I don't hand clients a deck and walk away. I come in. I stay. I direct execution until it's working.

I don't have a résumé. I have evidence. Sixty years of it. And I'm just getting started.

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